The Hundredfold Essence That Brings Understanding

Pratikarahṛdaśataka · Toh 1267 · Derge Tengyur
གཏོར་བདྲེ་པའ་སྙིང་པ་བོར་རྒྱ།

The Hundredfold Essence That Brings Understanding, whose Sanskrit title is given as Pratikarahṛdaśataka and whose Tibetan title is Gobar Jepé Nyingpo Gyapa, is a concise instructional treatise of the Hevajra tradition, composed by the Indian master Amitābhavajra, who is said to have received it from Hevajra himself. Opening with homage to Heruka and to the guru, it explains one's own mind as Hevajra and as the drop of awakening mind at the heart, and then sets out the practice in a sequence of stages concerned with the realities of speech, body, wind, mind and the ultimate. Along the way it describes visualizations of seed syllables and maṇḍalas, the channels Avadhūtī, Rasanā and Lalanā, the movement of the breath, the inner fire of caṇḍālī, and the signs of progress, all grounded in the view that phenomena are without intrinsic nature and are the display of mind. It is Toh 1267 in the Tengyur, where it is placed among the tantra commentaries.

In the language of India: pratikarahṛdaśataka nāma. In the language of Tibet: The Hundredfold Essence That Brings Understanding.

Homage to Heruka.

Why is homage paid to him? The intrinsic nature of all phenomena is expanded through the four joys, and it is surrounded by the vajra yoginīs. He is endowed with the splendor of the four wheels of emanation. That is why homage is paid to him.

Homage is also paid to the master. Why is homage paid to him? He has realized the meaning through the wisdom that does not conceive of cause and result as two, and he is supremely beautiful with great bliss. And since the master himself brings the disciple to understanding, he is the essence that brings understanding. That is why homage is paid to that master.

Next I shall explain the essence of the meaning. As for "Hevajra," one's own mind itself is Hevajra. Why is it one's own mind itself? Because it is free from all conceptual thought, and because it is unborn and unceasing; for in that nature of Heruka there is neither decrease nor increase. In practical terms, one imagines the awakening mind like a moon in one's own heart. It is the

drop from which manifold emanations are sent forth for the sake of beings and into which they are gathered back. Yet not even sending forth and gathering are needed: one should meditate constantly on the drop itself.

It is also called the maṇḍala, because one sends forth from it. It is also the very nature of the five kinds of wisdom. One meditates on it like a lamp flame unstirred by the wind. It is free from one and many, and unmoving. It is this that is called the deity of the maṇḍala. It is also the essence of the four joys, which dispel all darkness. The yogin who meditates on it constantly abandons all the afflictions. Form and all the rest are to be understood as without intrinsic nature; they are not to be abandoned.

What is it that is called the essence of all phenomena? It is this that is called the very essence of all. To meditate on emptiness and one's own mind as not different is to know the meaning of innate joy. If one realizes emptiness and one's own mind without conceiving them as two, that itself is the result. This is because the five aggregates are the nature of the five Tathāgatas, and their becoming manifest through meditation is the result.

As for "ḍākinī," it is because one's own channels themselves are of the nature of ḍākinīs. Meditating on them is the cause, and knowing them as ḍākinīs is the result. With a mind that cannot be expressed, one pervades all phenomena. As for "mudrā," it is all the forms of appearance and existence. "Hand emblem" refers to all the colors. When mental bliss arises in a yogin who meditates in this way, he is called a yogin who meditates on vajra and lotus.

One meditates on all phenomena, the aggregates and the rest, as of one taste. Since there is no mind separate from the body, one meditates that there is no body separate from the mind either. If one meditates in this way, the sun and the moon come to rest in that drop of awakening mind. That very drop is mind, and in that mind all phenomena appear. Mind itself is said to be a mirror. Just as no reflection appears in a mirror smeared with red paint, so wisdom does not arise unless the obscuration of one's own conceptual thought is cleared away. Therefore one becomes just as one meditates. From the time one has made one's own mind stable, one gathers all outer and inner phenomena into the drop by the light rays of that drop and meditates; in this way one should make it stable just so. And one meditates on it for a long time.

Why does one meditate on it? In order to clear away the conception of self and other, and so that there are no phenomena apart from mind. One should

always delight in meditation of this kind. With it one should also continually enjoy the five sense pleasures. However one enjoys them, there is no fault; they become a cause for gaining accomplishment, and do not become bondage.

If one meditates in this way for six months, signs appear. In the first, warmth arises. In the second, one displays emanations. In the third, one goes wherever one thinks of. In the fourth, a hair curl coiling to the right appears between the brows. In the fifth, the five superknowledges arise. In the sixth, from the drop at the heart, the drop that sees the sentient beings of the three realms, one is able to send forth all the sentient beings of the three realms and to gather them back. Having accomplished the benefit of beings by sending forth and gathering back in this way, one becomes Vajrasattva. It is said that if one is not able to do so for six months, then even for half a month, and through that, subtle signs will come. If one meditates in this way, one becomes a buddha.

Abandoning the conceptual thought of signs, one should meditate constantly. One should meditate on all phenomena as like an illusion.

If one meditates on all phenomena as emptiness, how does one act for the benefit of beings? It is like this: in darkness one does not see the things that are there, but when a light is raised one sees the objects. In the same way, being obscured by one's own conceptual thought, one does not see the true meaning. By meditating on the meaning given above, the light of omniscient wisdom will arise.

Now I shall explain the characteristics of body and speech, though this is not to leave the characteristic of mind unexplained. What is called Avadhūtī is the nature from which arises the nonconceptual wisdom in which method and wisdom are nondual. It is called the middle. Why is it called the middle? Because it is without beginning or end; and because it has abandoned existence and nonexistence, since it abides between the two. What is called existence is called Rasanā, and what is called nonexistence is called Lalanā. What are these two like? They are to be seen in the wheel of perfect enjoyment. Where is Avadhūtī to be known? It is to be known at the time when the two have become one.

Inside the larynx and the gullet, one imagines a syllable vaṃ in each. One imagines the two of them as two water maṇḍalas, and on top of these one imagines a vaṃ in each. One imagines these turning into lotuses, and

imagines an aṃ on the anthers of the lotus on the left side and a kaṃ on the anthers of the lotus on the right side. One meditates in this way for as long as possible. Then one imagines the two syllables turning into a sun and a moon, and imagines aṃ and kaṃ on top of the sun and moon. One meditates on this for a long time. Then, clenching the teeth and drawing the breath inward, the sun and moon become nondual, and nonconceptuality arises. If one is unable to clench the teeth and draw the breath inward, one should press the two channels of enjoyment; through that too wisdom will arise. By meditating in this way, bliss arises first, and from it nonconceptual wisdom surely arises.

What is that nonconceptuality like? It is so because it is free from both signs and the basis of signs. The yogin who abides in it sees all phenomena as like the eight examples of illusion. By meditating in this way for six months, one will attain the accomplishment of speech. What is that like? Whatever one says comes true. One who meditates in this way will be blessed by Amitābha. The reality of speech is complete.

Now I shall explain the reality of body. At the forehead, one imagines a wind maṇḍala arising from yaṃ, and above it one imagines oṃ. One imagines the oṃ turning into a moon maṇḍala. Between these two one imagines oṃ. One meditates in this way for a long time. Having thus generated the absorption at the forehead, one performs the completion stage: of clenching the teeth and drawing in the breath, pressing the two channels, and drawing the breath inward, one should do any two. From the first arising of bliss up to the seeing of things as like an illusion and so on, it accords with what was explained in the section teaching the reality of speech. The yogin who abides in this will be blessed by Vairocana. This teaches the accomplishment of body. The accomplishment of body is the ability to emanate various bodies. The reality of body is complete. Up to this point is for beginners.

Now I shall explain the reality of wind. Thirty sets of eighteen blinks of the eye are called one water-clock period. For one period the breath flows from the right nostril; this is of the nature of the sun. For one period it flows from the left nostril; this is of the nature of the moon. Each breath, right and left, is further to be known as fourfold. Of these, the four that flow downward are of the nature of water. The four that flow upward are of the nature of fire. The four that flow from the sides are of the nature of wind. The four that flow straight out are of the nature of earth. These four are of the nature of Locanā and the other goddesses. The space between the two nostrils is space, and that is of the nature of Heruka. The four goddesses come to be united in

Heruka, and at the time of their union nonconceptual wisdom arises.

By what cause does nonconceptual wisdom arise? At the time the four goddesses unite in Heruka, all the channels become filled with the awakening mind. How do the four goddesses unite in Heruka? The right wind flows for one period, and after it has entered, it flows from the left. Without letting it enter, one draws it to the right. Not remaining on the right, and by force of entering on the left, it meets Heruka in the middle. The left is to be understood in the same way. Therefore it is called the union of the four goddesses in Heruka. The instruction for this is to be learned from the guru's mouth.

When the four goddesses have thus united in Heruka, all accomplishments are to be known as of the nature of great bliss. Everything from the water-clock period up to the union of the four goddesses in Heruka is called the reality of wind. Through it the fire of great passion is kindled, the four wheels melt into light, and nonconceptual wisdom arises. All outer and inner things are one's own mind, and to know them as mind itself is called the burning of things. To know its nature is called caṇḍālī. The aggregates and everything else are burned. What is it? It is mind, and that very mind is called Avadhūtī. Knowing everything as of the nature of mind is called the descent of the nectar. The reality of mind is complete.

Now I shall explain the ultimate reality. The nature of speech is not established. Why is it not established? Because the body, the basis of speech, is itself not established. Why is the body not established? It is not established because, when examined, it is void. If the body were something with an essence of its own, it would not be reasonable for different states of mind, such as desire, to arise toward one and the same woman's body. Since its basis is not established, speech is unestablished, because its basis is unestablished. It is like the sound of a lute, for example: it arises from the coming together of causes and conditions, and so it is evident that it has no intrinsic nature. Different states of mind arise toward one thing, one sign. The yogin sees it ultimately as nondual wisdom, while others, by the power of conceptual thought, see it as manifold. Therefore, abiding in the absence of intrinsic nature, compassion arises for all sentient beings, and in order that sentient beings may attain liberation, I enter the absorption described above. Having entered it, one attains the result. One generates the resolve to act for the benefit of sentient beings.

The vajra-like absorption is this. In the sky before him the yogin imagines a wind maṇḍala arising from yaṃ. Above it he generates a fire maṇḍala from raṃ. Above that he generates a water maṇḍala from vaṃ. Above that he generates the source of phenomena from dhaṃ. Above that, from paṃ, a lotus. Above that, from khaṃ, a crossed vajra, and on its vase-like hub a sun maṇḍala, in the center of which is hūṃ. That hūṃ is of the nature of body, speech and mind. From it radiate five kinds of light rays, of the nature of the five colors, which invite the Tathāgatas together with their heirs, and the gurus. As they dissolve into that hūṃ, everything from the hūṃ down to the wind maṇḍala becomes a single drop of awakening mind, and one imagines the hūṃ abiding within the drop. With one's own breath one draws that drop in, and imagines the hūṃ at the tip of the nose. By meditating in this way day and night, signs appear: the mirage and the rest appear. If one meditates as described above, then from the arising of the bliss of mind, one comes to meet the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Through whatever stainless root of virtue
Has been gained by my composing this Essence That Brings Understanding,
May all the sentient beings of the three realms without exception
Clear away the net of conceptual thought
And attain unsurpassed awakening.

The Essence That Brings Understanding of All Phenomena, composed by the great master Amitābhavajra, which brings understanding of all phenomena by dividing a hundred ślokas into seven stages. It was granted to Amitābhavajra by glorious Hevajra, and he composed this text. This completes The Essence That Brings Understanding, composed by the great master Amitābhavajra from glorious Hevajra.

Translator's Notes

• Avadhūtī here renders □□□□□□□□□□□, literally "the all-conquering one," which in this context plainly names the central channel, set between Rasanā and Lalanā. In the sixth sign the phrase about the drop at the heart is repeated in the Tibetan, apparently by dittography; it has been rendered once as an apposition. "The things that are there" renders the unclear □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□.
• The sentence on the unestablished basis of speech is tautological in the Tibetan (literally "since the basis is not established, because the basis is not established"); it is rendered as completing the argument that speech is unestablished. The water-clock period renders □□□□□□, a unit of time (Skt. nāḍikā). The author's name, literally "Infinite Light Vajra," is given as Amitābhavajra, matching Amitābha for □□□□□□□□□□□□; the Sanskrit form is not otherwise confirmed.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.